more fortunate, he separated from each other ‘like dishevelled thread’ – just as he had dispersed the ataka khail from Punjab and should have dispersed the Qaqshals. ‘A large number of Shaikhs and Faqirs were also sent to . . . Qandahar,’ writes Badauni, ‘where they were exchanged for horses’ – that is, sold as slaves.[20]

A marked man might try and escape his fate with flattery, though with little guarantee of success. Badauni tells the story of a petrified Haji Ibrahim cooking up a forged manuscript filled with predictions of how the coming caliph would have many wives and be clean-shaven – much like Akbar – and ‘includ[ing] many other peculiarities of the Emperor’. At first, it seemed as if the trick was working, but Haji Ibrahim went too far when he began making fun of Abul Fazl and Hakim Abul Fath. Akbar packed him off to jail in Ranthambore, where he died.

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Bengal was in flames, his ulema in revolt, but Akbar was doing little, it seems, to soothe the suspicions of either his warlords or his court scholars. Not only had he invited the Jesuit Fathers and encouraged ‘so many wretches of Hindus and Hinduizing Musalmans’ to argue irreverently in his court, Akbar had even begun to make grand displays of his heresies. Thus, Akbar began the twenty-fifth year of his reign, in March 1580, with a grand and public prostration before the sun and fire; and ordered that the court ‘rise up respectfully’ when the evening’s lamps and candles were lit.[21]

This lighting of lamps would become an elaborate affair. As Abul Fazl describes it, every day, before sunset, Akbar would take off all his ornaments, thus ‘lay[ing] aside the splendor of royalty, and bring[ing] his external appearance in harmony with his heart’. Attendants would bring in twelve white candles on twelve candlesticks of silver and gold – some of them so tall that you needed a ladder to reach the wicks – and a singer, holding a candle, would sing ‘a variety of delightful airs to the praise of God’. The whole ceremony began and ended with prayers for the continuation of Akbar’s reign, while diyas were lit all around the palace and outside it. Besides the candles and diyas, there was also a seemingly sacred fire-pot called the Agingir, lit from a stone heated by the sun itself, and preserved the whole year round, to be used by lamplighters, torch bearers